

Bill Spencer

From: Coronado, Mark A <mark.coronado@rl.doe.gov>
Sent: Friday, March 3, 2017 11:56 AM
To: Bill Spencer; Adam Fyall; Adam Morasch
Cc: Olds, Theodore E (Erik); Jones, Gregory A (DOE); Kirsten Yniguez
Subject: RE: Information request on Benton County PILT for House Energy and Water Development Committee staff

Bill,

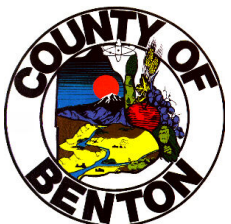
Thank you for your timely response on this. I will forward your response to HQ.

From: Bill Spencer [mailto:Bill.Spencer@co.benton.wa.us]
Sent: Friday, March 03, 2017 10:59 AM
To: Coronado, Mark A <mark.coronado@rl.doe.gov>; Adam Fyall <Adam.Fyall@co.benton.wa.us>; Adam Morasch <Adam.Morasch@co.benton.wa.us>
Cc: Olds, Theodore E (Erik) <Theodore_E_Erik_Olds@rl.doe.gov>; Jones, Gregory A (DOE) <gregory.jones@rl.doe.gov>; Kirsten Yniguez <Kirsten.Yniguez@co.benton.wa.us>
Subject: RE: Information request on Benton County PILT for House Energy and Water Development Committee staff

Mark,

1. Vineyards have never been assessed as farm land, only as improvements to farm land. The Open Space program was initiated in Washington State with passage of the Open Space Taxation Act in 1970, and does not apply to any improvements, only to the land that is enrolled in the program. (Applicable laws are RCW 84.34 and WAC 458-30. The process for applications would have made it effective no sooner than 1973 for taxes due, as it entails application year, followed by assessment year, and then effective in taxes the 3rd year.) This could be taken out.
2. Benton County has a number of land types: a) irrigated, both crop land and pasture, b) dry crop land, mainly wheat crop land, c) dry pasture, d) range (dry with minimal pasture usage), e) rural home-site, and farm buildings site. The irrigated, dry crop and dry pasture types have 3-5 quality ratings with graduated values for assessment purposes. Each parcel of land is assessed at market value for the acreage of each type it has, unless it is enrolled in the Open Space program.
3. No, there are different values. The values assigned are highest for best quality land and lowest for range land, all based on predominant sales prices of various land types. For example, present highest value is on #1 quality irrigated land in irrigation districts, followed by #2 quality, etc. Next is land irrigated by deep wells and river pumping plants. Dry crop land values are rated by their crop production ratings from #1 to #5.

Thanks,



Bill Spencer

Assessor
Benton County Assessor's Office
7122 W Okanogan Pl., Bldg A
Kennewick, WA 99336

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From: Coronado, Mark A [<mailto:mark.coronado@rl.doe.gov>]
Sent: Tuesday, February 28, 2017 1:14 PM
To: Adam Fyall <Adam.Fyall@co.benton.wa.us>; Bill Spencer <Bill.Spencer@co.benton.wa.us>; Adam Morasch <Adam.Morasch@co.benton.wa.us>
Cc: Olds, Theodore E (Erik) <Theodore_E_Erik_Olds@rl.doe.gov>; Jones, Gregory A (DOE) <gregory.jones@rl.doe.gov>; Kirsten Yniguez <Kirsten.Yniguez@co.benton.wa.us>
Subject: Information request on Benton County PILT for House Energy and Water Development Committee staff
Importance: High

Gentlemen,

We have received questions from House Energy and Water Development Committee staff related to Payment in Lieu of Taxes (PILT) and how Benton County classifies agricultural lands. The questions are:

- 1) What year did Benton County start to classify vineyards as farmland?
- 2) What are the different classifications of farmland in Benton County?
- 3) Are the different classifications of farmland treated the same in assessment and tax rate?

We would greatly appreciate it if you could provide us answers to these questions fairly quickly so we can respond. The questions above are exactly as we received them. Please answer to the extent possible. For your awareness, we have received multiple inquiries on PILT from HEWD staff, so they appear to have a substantial interest in PILT.

Please confirm via e-mail that you have received this request, and let me know if I should be addressing it to some other party within your organization. An estimate of when you can provide the requested information would be greatly appreciated.

Please call me if you have any questions.

Thank you,

Mark Coronado, Director
Budget Division, Richland Operations Office
509.376.5363